OUR CHILDREN (1)

Their Spiritual Welfare is Important Also

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The purpose of the International Year of the Child in 1979, was to highlight the needs and aspirations that children have around the world and to direct attention to the Declaration of Children's Rights adopted by the General Assembly of the United Nations twenty years ago, in 1959. The hope, so far as Australia was concerned, was that by the end of the year and as a result of the publicity and activities that were being organised in connection with the Year of the Child, "Australians will have a deeper awareness of all children's needs and (come to) care for kids everywhere."

The emphasis was on bettering life and conditions and opportunities for children in this world. And in the light of the statistics, who of us would assert that such an emphasis was misplaced? At that time, of the 1.5 billion children under 15 yrs of age in the world, it is said 200 million never get a chance to learn reading, writing or counting. More than 500 million (a third of the total number) are threatened by malnutrition, and half of them (250 million) suffer from under nourishment. These are statistics that represent an enormous challenge to the governments and peoples of the world, and we all wondered what we could do to help alleviate the problems that exist.

Life in this world is important. And we applaud and support every effort to give children opportunities which in many cases and in certain circumstances have always been denied them, and to free them from the tyranny of poverty and malnutrition. But our responsibility to our children by no means ends with this world. Much is said about the physical and mental welfare of children, and action is promised in certain areas. But there is yet another aspect which we would not want to lose sight of, and that is the spiritual welfare of our children. Life in this world is important. The physical and mental welfare of our children is important. They have a right to basic dignities which in many cases are denied them.

However, their spiritual welfare is also important. We must fit them to take their rightful place not just in this world, but in the spiritual world, in heaven, when in time they die. However well we prepare and equip our children for life in this world (and there is no question but that we must do this) our responsibilities to them don't end there. And it is these further responsibilities we have to them that I want to relate.

Clearly our attitude to our children, our approach to them and our emphasis with them is going to be heavily governed and influenced both by what we understand to be their relationship to us and what we understand to be the purpose of life in this world. The natural tendency, which we are not always successful in resisting, is to think of our children as our very own, and to take the attitude that we are responsible to no one so far as their upbringing is concerned. Often lurking within our attitude to them is an element of self love which we must shun. We bask in the praise that is heaped upon them and unless we shun the inclination, want to vicariously enjoy their accomplishments.

However the truth is our children are not our own. Our children belong to the Lord. And they are given into our care by Him so that we might know and share and enjoy the experience and responsibility of caring for them. We do not own or possess our children. We are responsible to the Lord for their welfare. And this knowledge should be at the heart of the relationship we enjoy with them.

And then there is the question of what we understand to be the purpose of life in this world. How important this also is. For some, the purpose of life is seen to be relationship to this world only. The purpose of life, they would say, is to be educated, have a successful career, to perhaps marry and to have children. And those who do so, have achieved the purpose of their existence. In Swedenborg's Writings the purpose of life is shown to be a whole lot different to this. The purpose of life is that we should use the experiences that come to us here to come to terms with the fallen

inclinations we all possess, to overcome them and to better fit ourselves to serve the Lord, not only in this world, but also in heaven when we die.

Therefore our principal goal with our children should not be their worldly prosperity and success, but their spiritual well being and a meaningful relationship with the Lord. So often we hear of someone referred to as a 'failure' and someone else referred to as a 'success'. If our children don't achieve as we want them to or think they should be able to, we tend to think of them also as 'failures'. The reason we talk like this is because we have in mind and are thinking from wrong goals for them and from a misunderstanding of the whole purpose of life. The real question and what matters most of all, is whether our children learn to truly care for others; to overcome the loves of self and the world; and become more like the Lord in their attitudes and behaviour. All who have anything to do with the welfare of children do well to reflect on the question which the Lord Himself asked: ‘What good will it be for someone to gain the whole world, yet forfeit their soul? Or what can anyone give in exchange for their soul?’ Matthew 16:26

In a passage which gives us a great deal to think about, Swedenborg wrote of a sight seen in the spiritual world - mothers cruelly combing the hair of their children. This represented (or pictured) "the education of little children at this day" (*Arcana Caelestia* 2125). And though we wince when we think about it we can see what was being got at - parents imposing materialistic values on their children and setting their sights on the passing goals of worldly success and renown. So much harm can be done. So many obstacles placed in their way.

And this brings me on to my next point, concerning spiritual rebirth or regeneration. Possessed of fallen tendencies as we all are; tendencies to love ourselves and to love the world more than to love the Lord and to love our neighbour; we must, as the Lord insisted, be born again. The process of rebirth or regeneration is something that each of us by ourselves must initiate. We can't regenerate others. Only the Lord can do this, and even He must wait until He is invited to do so. It is in fact as adults, when we are in command of our own lives; thinking from ourselves and for ourselves, and able to enter into a freely chosen relationship with the Lord, that regeneration is able to get under way.

Even though this is so, there is a great deal that takes place in the years beforehand and established in childhood as a result of the influences with which they have been surrounded; and the general direction of a person's life, can be very difficult to break free from. Because it illustrates the point so well I would like to quote Swedenborg describing one of his own experiences. Many children on earth, though, receive quite an opposite kind of upbringing, as I was able to see from just this one example: ‘I was on the street of a large city when I saw some youngsters brawling. A crowd gathered excitedly to watch, and I learned that parents goad their own little children to fight like this. The good spirits and angels said to do so, the parents extinguish all mutual love on the very threshold of life. It is to snuff out all the innocence children receive from the Lord and initiate them into hatred and revenge. By their own efforts the parents are banishing their children from heaven, where mutual love is everything.’ *Arcana Caelestia* 2309

Children have their own abilities, personalities and talents and they are bound to develop in their different ways. However we can certainly introduce them into attitudes and patterns of selfishness which, when at last it commences, must make their regeneration that much more difficult. The teaching given is that ‘anything we think, intend, say, and do from the time we are very small latches on to our life and becomes part of it. Such elements cannot be eliminated, only pushed to the sides.’ *Arcana Caelestia* 9333

It is not easy for us always to remember in the face of lack of success or only mediocre achievements that what really matters in life is the character and spiritual development of our children. Everywhere the emphasis is on achievement. The social sections of our news papers are full of the news of the rich and accomplished and those who are successful in a worldly way. We find it difficult to put these things on one side, as being the insignificant and unimportant things which they are. The really important thing is for us to remember what the Lord is trying to do; what are the goals He has in mind for our children; and to cooperate with Him to the fullest

possible extent in achieving these. He is trying to lead our children to find happiness in a life that is none other than the life of heaven. What He wants for our children is sincerity and honesty, humility and the willingness to make sacrifices for the good of others. And what we must do is to take all opportunities to instil these qualities in them.

A good part of the means of doing this will be by means of instruction - talking to our children about the Lord and making sure they are adequately instructed in the teaching He has given us. Also we teach by attitude and example. And in this regard the importance of tenderness in adult relationships, consideration of others and our own willingness to humble ourselves before the Lord cannot be stressed too much.